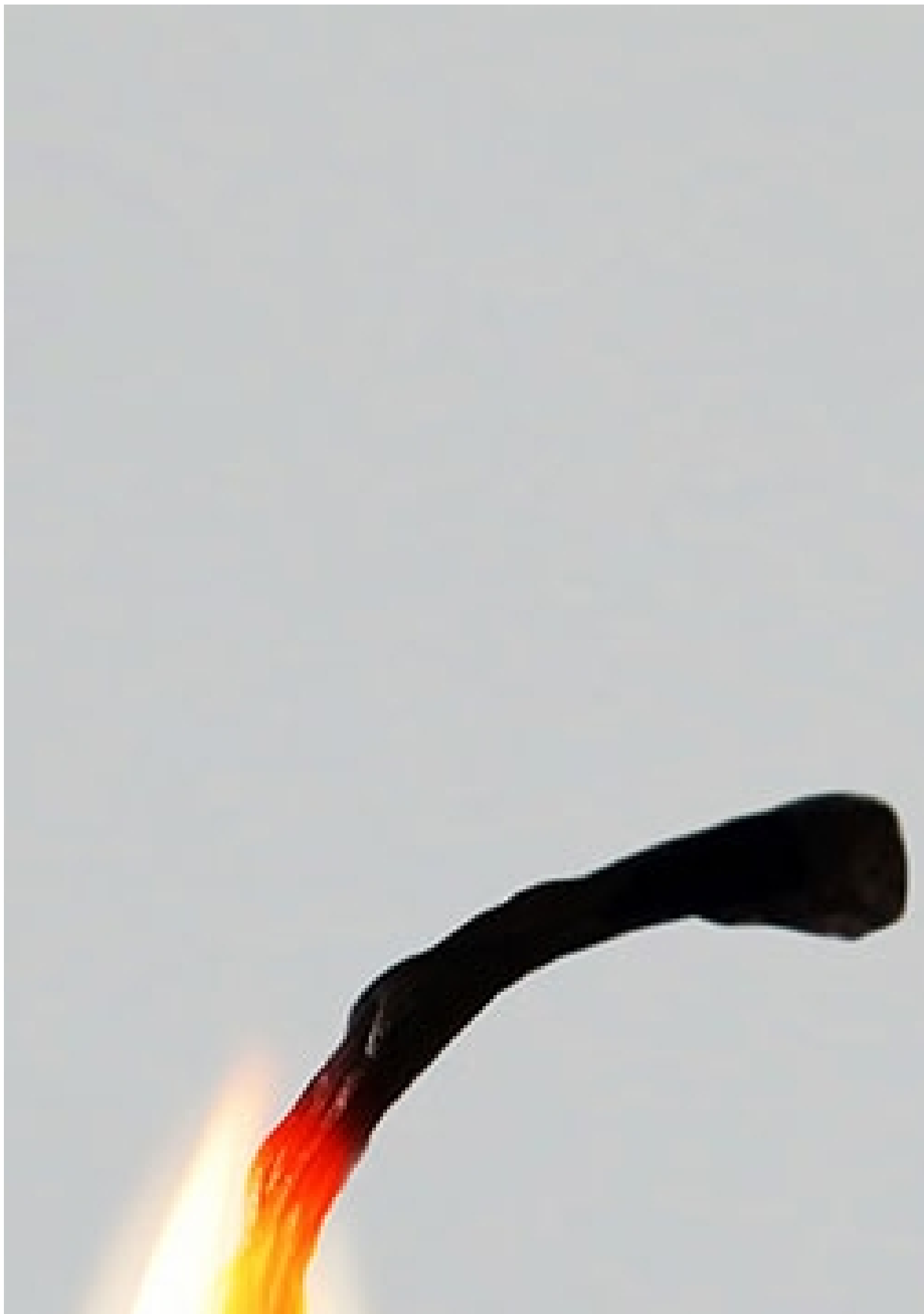


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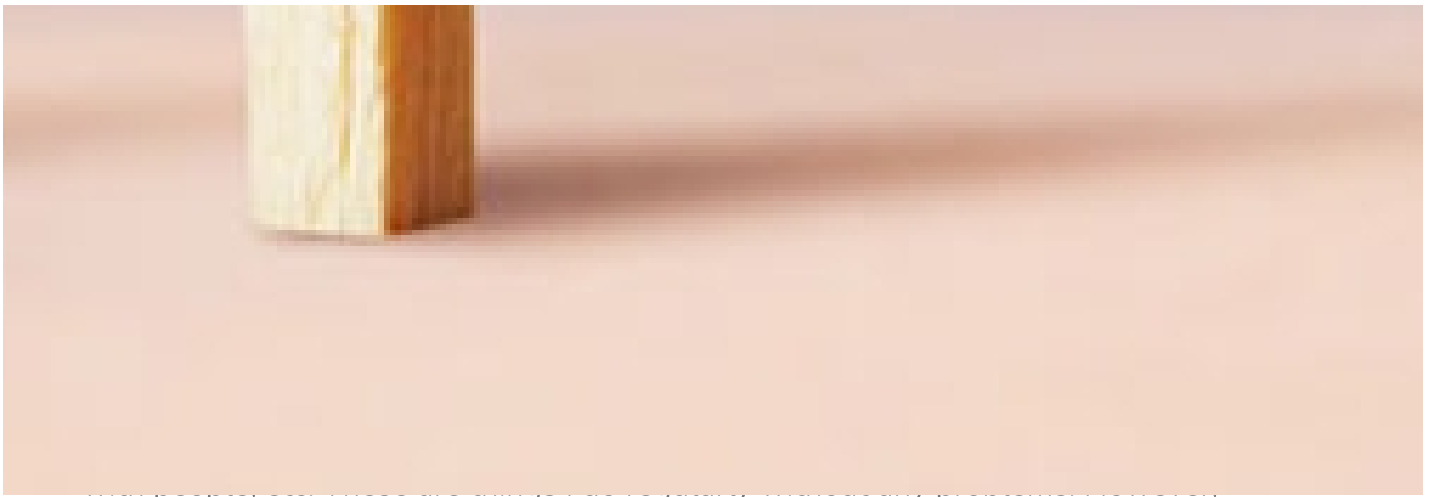
How I Recognize And Prevent Burnout In Open Source

ROOT · MAY 26, 2021 · 5 MINUTE READ









when burnout is approaching, the thought of doing an everyday task makes me want to stay in bed in the morning.

2. **Going into a shell (and avoiding others):** When things get stressful, I start avoiding contact with others. It's not just that I'm busy; I start avoiding social interactions with people in work *and* non-work settings.
3. **Not being a good family member or friend:** I'm actually very embarrassed to discuss this, but I need to because this is a big red flag for me. When I'm really burned out, I start getting snappy and lose my cool with my family and friends. I may even say something I regret almost immediately and feel horrible guilt about it. Unfortunately, I start pushing away people when I probably need them the most.

If I notice any of these signs, I know it's time to do something. It doesn't have to be a week-long vacation in the tropics; even if it's a quick afternoon hike, I need to find ways to step away. Like in a basketball game, a quick timeout can help me regroup before things really spiral downward.

Preventing burnout

Knowing your warning signs is important, but it's even more important to take preventative measures to avoid reaching that point. Here are some of the things that help me:

1. **Use a mantra to refocus:** When my daughter was a baby, my morning routine after breakfast was to play with her in the living room while waiting for our nanny. I remember feeling sleep-deprived and wanting to check messages on my phone while watching her play. To silence the

urge to pick up the phone, I developed a mantra that went something like, “this [being with my daughter] is the most important thing for you right now” to help put me in the right frame of mind. I still use the mantra when I need to remind myself that being fully present with someone is more important than anything else.

2. **Take a short break:** One of the things I like to do (at least until the pandemic made this difficult) is to have lunch with local community members, friends, or former co-workers. These lunches break the monotony of having lunch by myself at home and help me connect with other people. After each of these lunches, I always think, “I should do this more often.” I also try to squeeze in time for physical activity—I’m not talking about training for a marathon. I do enjoy running, but I haven’t run a race in over 10 years. Whenever I feel like I don’t have the time to exercise, I remind myself that even five minutes of running has long-lasting health benefits. Surely, everyone can invest five to 10 minutes a day for their well-being.
3. **Be disciplined about taking time away from work:** I have been fortunate to work with many leaders who are supportive of me taking time off and modeled scheduling vacations and blocking off their calendars for family commitments. I try to do the same. I make sure people know when I’m taking vacation, taking my daughter to school, volunteering, and so on. By letting people know when I will be away, I feel more empowered to not think about work for a while and focus on what’s in front of me.

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Taking care of ourselves and others

I’m sure you have your own warning signs for burnout and tips for avoiding it, and I look forward to reading your ideas in the comments.

Before I close, I want to return to the question I asked at the top: Are we doing a poor job of taking care of ourselves? This was a rhetorical question, but the truth is that, in addition to taking better

care of ourselves, we need to pay attention to and help the people around us.

If you see someone overwhelmed with stress, volunteer to help and remember to follow up with them—especially when you're in a remote work environment. If this doesn't work, reach out to their managers, colleagues, or others so that they're not dealing with the situation alone. As we've learned during the global pandemic, when someone suffers, the impact is not just limited to that person. It affects all of us, and we need the courage to speak up and help them get better. Otherwise, more people will continue going through this vicious cycle.

Burnout, stress, and work-life balance are important topics that will long be discussed at conferences and in articles like this. However, my sincere hope is that people will no longer suffer on their own because no one spoke up to help them.

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